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MY POWAI

Volume No. 13 Issue No. 12 Mumbai August 2025

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Step into the world of **The Chaat Boutique**, where bhel finds a fiery new soulmate in siracha and wasabi, Jodhpuri Mirchi Vada arrives wrapped in golden crunch and stuffed with spiced warmth and the humble vada pav is reborn as Thecha Gold Toast — a grilled sandwich oozing molten cheese and Maharashtrian thecha. These aren't your usual suspects. They're rebels on a plate — bold, cheeky and impossible to ignore. Because some flavours don't tiptoe onto your tongue. They arrive roaring.

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Dear friends

There was no shortage of rain in Powai this month, and that brought with it potholes and terrible roads. Tragically, a life was lost on JVLR due to a massive pothole — a stark reminder that BMC officials must be held accountable for such negligence.

On brighter pages, Sherry Bhatnagar takes us on a culinary journey through the North East of India — a region whose flavours remain a mystery to many. And if you'd like to taste Sherry's creative fusion, do check out The Chaat Boutique on Zomato.

In this issue, our nutritionist Nisha Singh sheds light on fatty liver — a topic that's sparked many conversations among friends lately. A healthy liver, after all, is key to a healthy body. Uma Kumaravelan shares a thoughtful piece on one family's journey into smart investing — a must-read for anyone looking to plan their financial future. And, as always, popular astrologer Richa Pathak brings you predictions to help navigate the month ahead.

We cover everything that matters to Powai and Chandivali. Follow us on X and Instagram for the latest updates and stories from your neighbourhood.

Happy reading!
Warm regards,

Mahesh Kutty
(Editor)

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What's coming in the way of Fire Safety in Powai high rises



D.P.K. Udas

The scenic suburb of Powai has grown multifold in last 25 years.

Hiranandani Gardens created the township and many multi-Storey buildings have come up.

This was followed by other developers like Powai Vihar, MHADA, Union Bank, L&T, Srishti, Wadhwa etc.

Many other developers chose Chandivali to develop which includes Raheja, Nahar, Tata Housing, Kalpataru, S&P, Godrej etc.

Now how safe are these high rises?
We talked to Fire Officers at Mumbai Fire Brigade. As per them, the nearest Fire Stations for Powai are Vikhroli & Marol. In view of Fire reported at Lake Homes and time taken to reach by Fire tankers it was decided to make Fire Station in this area. The lot of search was done but the corporation could not provide plot of sufficient size. One plot provided on Chandivali Farm Road is very small and Mini Fire Station was erected.

Mumbai Fire Brigade was established in 1855. They have 170 years of experience in dousing fire. In addition to this basic duty they also do:

- Save people in flood affected areas.
- Removal of fallen trees
- Bird & Animal rescue
- Gas leak control
- Road & Rail accidents

The Fire Brigade has annual budget of about Rs 104 crores. This is spent on workforce, training and purchase of equipment.

They have Bronto Skylift for Skyscrapers. These are good and useful for areas like Powai.

For narrow lanes of Tirandaz village there are Royal Enfield bullets mounted with Firefighting equipment which will reach the spot very quickly.

Fire Brigades also uses robots which can go inside Fire infested area, locate living objects and remove them.

Mumbai Municipal Corporation (Bmc) has strict vigil on Fire Safety of Mumbaikars. The budget of Mumbai Fire Brigade comes from BMC. They also encourage them to use full budget.



The Fire Safety clearance is required to be taken by Restaurants, Nursing Homes, EV Charging stations, cloud kitchens etc.
Even temporary structures for religious ceremonies will require Fire Safety compliance.

For new buildings OC is given only after they are Fire compliant. Same applies to commercial complexes as well.

One of the main reasons for Fire is **Short Circuit.** It is advised to use good material and periodic inspection.

We asked Fire Officer about what is the major constraint about catering to Powai in case of the unfortunate incident. The answer is **"Traffic".**

We checked on Google map as to how much time will it take to reach 'Powai Plaza' from ' Marol Fire Station'. The answer is 36 mins for 6.1 kms.

This reading is at 4 pm. After 6 pm you can assume that it would take double the time thru Saki Naka.

If fire tankers are going to reach you after 1 hour then considerable property shall be damaged by then.

What is the way out then?
Each building is equipped with fire extinguishers, hose pipes, sprinkler system etc. It is better to start dousing the Fire as soon as it is reported. Each building to create volunteers in the event of such incident. Regular training of residents is required. Fire drills every 6 months are must.

This will also ensure that alarms and equipment are in working condition.

We also need to take up with the State Govt. for allocation of bigger plot for " Fire Station" at Powai.

(The author is long time resident of Powai. He takes up civic issues with the authorities. He has been instrumental in improving illumination in the area, zebra crossings , garbage removal etc.)



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Grand Yoga Day Celebration in Powai: a blend of devotion, wellness and wisdom



A grand yoga event filled with devotion, wellness, and wisdom was organised at the Megarugas Hall, Chandivali, under the aegis of Akshardham Swaminarayan Temple, Powai, in association with Jalaja Foundation and Kripalu Yoga.

The event began with a warm welcome speech by Yoga instructor Prachi Tyagi, who beautifully emphasised that yoga is not just a practice but a way of life, as enunciated by Lord Krishna in the Bhagavad Gita: "योगः कर्मसु कौशलम् ".The morning unfolded with a deep pragatya ceremony, followed by a soulful Swagat Nritya and a heartfelt welcome prayer, setting a cultural and emotional rhythm to the gathering.

Key highlights of the event included the felicitation of alumni and teachers, the celebration of 11 years of global yoga awareness, and the blissful announcement of a grand upcoming project by Yogi Divine Society, aimed at the spiritual upliftment of society.

A proud moment of the event was the launch of the book 'Amrit Vani of a Yogi – Part 1', authored by Mrs. Nupur Paresh Paul under the divine guidance of Dr. Deepak Parmar. The occasion was blessed by the presence of spiritual leaders P.P. Bharat Bhai, Vashi Bhai, and Guruji Narendra Brahmachari.Dr. Deepak Parmar, PhD Yoga (Stress Management), delivered a moving address, sharing his inspiring yoga journey from 1987 to 2025. The Chief Guest, Shri Sanjay Upadhyay (BJP MLA, Borivali), and advocate J.P. Shetty (BJP Leader, founder of Jalaja Foundation), also shared words on the importance of yoga in today's life.

The occasion concluded with blessings from Guruji Narendra Brahmachari and P.P. Bharat Bhai.

Several community members shared heartfelt testimonials, making the event a true reflection of service, self-discipline, and collective harmony.



Evergreen karaoke singing group organises "Melodious Monsoon Memories"

The Evergreen Karaoke Singing Group recently organised a delightful event titled Melodious Monsoon Memories – Aayi Barkha Bahar at Clubhouse Restaurant, Powai.

The singers, aged between 40 and 80 years, transported the audience through a musical journey spanning songs from the 1920s to 2020s. Both solos and duets were performed, featuring timeless monsoon melodies like Aaj Rapat Jaaye, Tip Tip Barsa Pani, Badal Yun Garajta Hai, O Sajana Barkha Bahar Aayi, Rimjhim Ke Tarane Leke, Jhoomta Mausam Dum Dum Diga Diga, Ek Ladki Bheegi Bhaagi Si, Rimjhim Gire Sawan, Mausam Hai Aashiqana, Garjat Barsat Sawan Aayo Re, Naino Mein Badra Chhaye, Sun Sun Sun Barsat Ki Dhun, Lagi Aaj Sawan Ki, Phir Sawan Aaye Ya Na Aaye, Bheegi Bheegi Raaton Mein, Ghar Aaja Ghir Aaye, Mere Naina Sawan Bhadon, Sawan Ka Mahina, Chhoti Si Kahani Se, Dekho Mausam Kya Bahar Hai, Yeh Mausam Rangeen Sama, Barkha Rani Zara Jam Ke Barso, Aaj Mausam Bada, Kabhi Jo Badal Barse, Zindagi Bhar Nahin Bhulegi, O Ghata Sawari, and Aise Bhi Sawan Aise Barse, among many others.



Prizes were awarded to early birds for punctuality and to the best-dressed participants. To enhance the monsoon theme, colourful umbrellas were used by the singers, lending an authentic touch to the performances. The sound system and recording further amplified the experience. Guests and participants were warmly welcomed with hot tea and pakodas, setting the perfect mood for the rainy season.

The evening concluded with a sumptuous dinner, and a group photograph was taken to capture the memorable occasion.Evergreen Karaoke Singing Group organises themed musical gatherings every month.
To join or learn more, contact organiser Bhupendra Shah at 93246 62290.

- Preeti Oka

Rooted in passion: Apra Vaidya's transition from tech to terrariums

Apra Vaidya, a qualified MCA by profession, spent five successful years climbing the corporate ladder. But life had bigger plans. As she embraced motherhood, she also took on the role of CEO not just at home, but by stepping in to support her husband's business.

Balancing boardroom decisions and parenting duties, Apra channelled her energy into two priorities: ensuring her son thrived in school and driving her husband's business to new heights.

Then came 2020. In the stillness of a post COVID world, Apra decided to reconnect with a long-lost love, gardening. That spark of passion led to the birth of **Urban Garden Studio (UGS)**.

Like most startup journeys, UGS began with humble roots but quickly found fertile ground. With her eye for detail and natural flair for green innovation, Apra didn't stop at just planting ideas she grew them. Enrolling as a student after 15 years, she joined the **Bonsai Study Group of the Indo Japanese Association** and formally trained under Bonsai **stalwarts Mr & Mrs Parekh**. Her dedication and craft earned her training opportunities with celebrated masters like **Ms Sujata Bhat, Veer Chowdhary and Rudi Julian** to at the prestigious **SABF conference**.

Today, **Urban Garden Studio** is a go to name among corporates for employee engagement workshops, nature inspired mementos for dignitaries, and all things **"go green."**

What's So Special About Urban Garden Studio?

Urban Garden Studio isn't just a green



"Amazon Rainforest" Paludarium



Apra Vaidya
Founder Urban Garden Studio

brand it's a movement that blends nature, art and well-being into every creation. Apra's passion and precision have helped shape UGS into a pioneer in eco aesthetics where every product tells a story, and every workshop leaves a lasting impression.

Here's what sets Urban Garden Studio apart:

Signature miniature bonsai creations: Each bonsai is a living sculpture, crafted with care and inspired by traditional Japanese techniques blended with Indian sensibilities.

Custom green gifts with a story & soul: From personalized terrariums, bonsai, kokedamas, living art installations to themed plant bouquets, UGS designs gifts that are alive, symbolic and meaningful perfect for dignitaries, guests or milestone events.

Workshops that spark mindfulness & creativity: UGS conducts hands on workshops that go beyond "just planting" they promote mental wellness, team bonding and a connection with nature.

Eco designs that redefine work spaces Be it reception lobbies, executive desks, or breakout zones, UGS greenifies corporate spaces with Zen gardens, rock scapes and palludarium that calm the mind and elevate the mood.

A one stop studio for green artistry from **Kokedamas** and **Tamandamas** to **exotic plants, miniature landscapes and terrariums**, UGS offers a curated variety of living art that suits every aesthetic. Whether it's **corporate gifting, employee engagement** or simply bringing **nature back to the centre,** UGS is rooted in purpose and blossoming with possibilities.

An early morning chat with family, set against the serene backdrop of her life sized palludarium a mesmerizing slice of nature right in her living room. You don't need a trip to a hill station or the grandeur of a waterfall to feel embraced by nature. The gentle sound of flowing water, the lush greenery and the calming ambiance it's all part of her daily routine. For her, peace doesn't need planning. It lives right at home.

Looking ahead, Apra dreams of creating a boutique space where nature and learning coexist in harmony. A place not just to shop but to experience. Where learning the art of bonsai, terrariums and living landscapes is not intimidating but **fun, therapeutic and part of a mindful lifestyle.** Her vision is to build a sanctuary where people can drop by, slow down, get their hands into soil, breathe in greenery and **spend a few peaceful hours reconnecting with nature right in the heart of the city.**



Plantscapes @ Urban Garden Studio

Because for Apra, it's not just about growing plants. It's about growing peace, presence and a greener way of life.

Follow Urban Garden Studio on Instagram and Facebook:
https://www.instagram.com/urbangardenstudio.in

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Nano Paludarium

Watering dreams: a family's journey into smart investing



It was a peaceful Sunday in Powai. Rohit, Meera, and their 10-year-old daughter Tara sat on their balcony flipping through old photos.

Tara pointed to one and asked, "Papa, what's this small house?"

Rohit smiled. "That was our first rented home. We didn't have much, but we had big dreams."

"We didn't know how to invest," Meera added. "Only how to save."

Tara asked, "Is there a way to make money grow?"

That's when Rohit remembered something his father once said:

"Money is like a tree. You plant, water, and wait. One day, it gives shade and fruit."

He began explaining how they now plant and grow their money.

SIP – Systematic Investment Plan
"Each month, we invest a fixed amount in mutual funds—called a SIP. It's like planting seeds regularly. Over time, they grow into something big."

"Like the tulsi plant I water every day?" Tara asked.

"Exactly," Meera said. "It takes care and patience."

STP – Systematic Transfer Plan
"Once, when Naani gifted us money," Rohit added, "we didn't invest it all at once. We parked it in a safe fund and moved it bit by bit into equity. That's called STP. Like using a small pipe instead of pouring all at once."

SWP – Systematic Withdrawal Plan
"And when we grow older," Meera said, "we'll use SWP to withdraw a little every month from what we've built. Like sipping from a pot you filled over the years."

Tara smiled. "So SIP is planting, STP is growing, and SWP is enjoying!"
They all laughed. It wasn't about jargon or markets. It was about values—consistency, care, and long-term thinking.

A Tree That Keeps Giving
That Sunday afternoon, Tara didn't just learn about money—she learned about patience, care, and purpose.

Rohit and Meera knew they weren't just building wealth; they were building a life of dignity and freedom.

Because when you plant your money with wisdom and water it with time…
It gives your family shade for a lifetime.

- Uma Kumaravelan
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Whispers by the lake



Chaarvi Athawale

The morning mist hangs low over Powai Lake, wrapping the water in a hush. The city hasn't woken up yet, but Powai is already breathing, softly, steadily, like it always has. The lake reflects the hazy skyline of buildings and trees. A peaceful mirror of the city, and yet, below the surface, a storm brews quietly every year.

Soon, Ganesh Chaturthi will return with its colours and chants. The beats of dhol will echo through Powai's lanes. Idols, big and small, will be ushered into homes, offices, mandals. And like always, they'll eventually find their way into the lake, gnawing at its silty bed, leaching the aquatic life.



But today, Powai is watching.

6:15 AM: Tara, the Jogger
Tara's shoes thud softly on the pathway as she runs along the lake. She stops. Not because she's tired, but because she spots something partially buried in the mud. Close to the edge lies a discarded thermocol mould, last year's festivity decoration, perhaps.

She picks it up, irritated at first. But her irritation soon turns inward. "We do this," she thinks. "We celebrate with one hand and strangle with the other."

She ties the waste to her fanny pack. It'll go in the recycling bin. One less piece sinking into the lake this year.

8:00 AM: Arjun, the IIT Student
Arjun, buried in his textbook, sits on a bench, by the lake. He's stuck on a fluid mechanics equation; the irony not lost on him as he watches a discarded garland float across the surface.

He's reminded of this year's college climate panel. He had spoken passionately about systems thinking, how human actions create ripple effects, how what you dump in water today ends up seeping into the soil and air, damaging ecosystems beyond repair. And yet here he is, watching the same problem repeat.



He opens his phone, drafts a short post for the campus group. "How about a student clean-up drive? This time, before the festival starts."

10:30 AM: Kavita Tai, the shopkeeper
For over two decades, Kavita Tai has been a familiar presence at all of Powai's bustling markets, selling pooja essentials beneath her faded red canopy. Year after year, her table brims with fragrant garlands, incense sticks, and carefully wrapped idols.

But this August, a small handwritten sign now rests at the corner of her stall: "Eco-friendly visarjan? Ask me how."

When a father and his young daughter stop by, curious, Kavita gently shares about the artificial immersion pond in Mumbai, a cleaner, kinder alternative to the lake. The father hesitates, unsure, but the little girl's eyes sparkle as she says, "Let's do it this year, Baba."

Kavita's smile deepens. She knows well, change begins with a single step, a single ripple.

4:00 PM: The Lake
If the lake could speak, it would say: "I remember."

The way the wind once skimmed across its clear waters. The way Kingfishers used to visit. The way its finned friends would glide through the murky depths.

It does not blame the people. It watches instead, the jogger picking trash, the student mobilising peers and the shopkeeper planting quiet seeds. Every action, a domino nudging the next.

For every bit of care, the lake feels a little lighter.

7:30 PM: The Choice
A petition initiated urging devotees to stop immersing idols of the Lord in the lake. The support of over 3,000 environmentally conscious Mumbaikars, united in their efforts to endorse the appeal. A conscious choice to redirect the flow of untreated sewage away from the lake and construct treatment plants at Powai Lake.

Tonight, as the city quiets and the lake breathes beneath the stars, there is hope; a hope that this choice will be the ripple that brings healing.



This petition reflects a community's commitment to protecting Powai Lake. As Ganesh Chaturthi nears, let's all commit to making simple, responsible choices that can help preserve Powai Lake, a shared space that connects the past, present, and future of Powai.

Follow us

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When “Yes” meets “No”: power struggles and parenting in front of teens



Debika Chaudhuri

It was supposed to be a relaxing Saturday afternoon. The kind where families slow down, reconnect, maybe even enjoy some ice cream.

For 17-year-old Vivaan, it started just like that, until one question changed everything.

“Can I go to a party tonight?” he asked his dad casually, as they walked down the street.

“Sure,” his dad replied, trying to sound open-minded.

“No way,” his mom cut in sharply. “Especially not with those kids.”

The conversation shifted fast from a teen asking for independence to a full-blown argument between his parents. Right there, in public.

“You’re always so controlling,” Vivaan’s dad snapped.

“And you’re always too passive,” she shot back.

Vivaan froze. His cheeks burned. He looked around, hoping no one he knew had seen. And then, without another word, he walked off.

It wasn’t about the party anymore. It was about power.

When Power Struggles Replace Parenting

Vivaan’s story is more common than we think. In homes where boundaries are unclear and decisions are made on the fly, teens quickly learn to find cracks and fall through them. But more than that, they become witnesses to adult dynamics that deeply shape how they see authority, trust, and even love.

In this case, Vivaan’s parents unintentionally made the conversation about each other, not Vivaan. The message he received? Approval depends on who “wins,” not on what’s best for him.

Over time, Vivaan began challenging teachers, pushing limits, and hiding parts of his life. Authority no longer felt safe, it felt arbitrary.

QUOTE BOX:

“In moments of disagreement, your child is not watching to see who’s right. They’re watching to see if love still leads the conversation.”

— EQ Parenting Principle



Conversations That Break Connection

Power struggles in front of teens can break trust faster than broken promises. Statements like:

- “You’re too soft with him.”
- “You never listen to me in front of him.”
- “Fine, do whatever you want then.”

aren’t just jabs between parents. To a teen, they signal chaos. These conversations, when aired publicly or emotionally, teach teens to manipulate, retreat or rebel.

Conversations That Build Trust

Emotional intelligence (EQ) is the cornerstone of resilient parenting. It’s not just about managing emotions, but understanding the emotions beneath the behavior, yours and your child’s.

So what could Vivaan’s parents have done instead?

1. Press Pause.

Instead of reacting immediately, one of them could’ve said:

"Thanks for bringing it up, Vivaan. Let us chat and get back to you in a bit."

This simple pause prevents escalation and shows mutual respect between parents.

2. Align Privately.

Behind closed doors, they could explore their concerns. Perhaps mom has safety worries. Maybe dad wants to show trust. Both perspectives matter but the decision becomes collaborative, not competitive.

3. Return United.

Coming back to Vivaan with a calm, shared response, even if it’s a “no”, shows emotional maturity.

"We talked about it and here’s what we’ve decided..." gives Vivaan clarity and models healthy communication.

4. Name the Growth.

If the answer is “no,” they can still honor Vivaan’s growing independence:

"We know it’s frustrating. You’re getting older, and we want to keep finding ways to give you more freedom, safely."

Shifting from Power to Partnership

Teen years are often filled with negotiation. But when parents use EQ tools, like self-awareness, empathy, and compassion, the home transforms from a battlefield to a partnership.

The goal isn’t to avoid conflict. The goal is to manage it wisely.

As for Vivaan? He may not have gone to that party. But if his parents had handled the moment differently, he might not have walked away angry. He might have felt heard, even in a disagreement.

And that’s a win more powerful than getting the last word.

(The author, Debika Chaudhuri, runs Elzix Foundation, an Educational Consultancy for the past twelve years. She has studied across three continents and has close to three decades of experience as an Executive Educator and Career Coach. She and her team help young people make important choices at critical junctures of their lives; develop self-confidence, if they don’t know what to do; help develop their skills to make the right fit; create life-changing educational experiences and help them with college admissions. She may be reached at debikac@elzixfoundation.com)

The Spice Chronicles

Walk into any home in India, and you are bound to catch the unmistakable aroma of spices. From the comforting crackle of cumin in hot oil to the warm scent of cardamom rising from a cup of chai, spices aren't just ingredients in our food, but now they hold stories, traditions, and a dash of magic, our mothers swear by. As a science student, the way I look at spices has evolved over the years. I don't think of them just as flavours, but as tiny packets of culture, chemistry, and comfort.

More than just taste

We often associate spices with flavour, and rightfully so, as our food wouldn't be the same without them. However, long before we had refrigerators or air-tight containers, spices played a different role. Clove, cinnamon, and mustard seeds all have natural properties that have helped preserve food and keep it edible in our hot and humid climate. That little tadka our mothers add to dal? It wasn't just for taste; it helped make the food last longer, too. So every time we see someone add a bay leaf to rice, or mustard seeds to a pickle, it is a practice passed down through generations. Something that hasn't been created in science labs but in kitchens in our homes.

Rituals We Didn't Know Were Rituals

Turmeric isn't just a spice in our masala dabba but a part of weddings, pujas, and school projects (who else remembers painting with haldi and water?). Every spice in our kitchen seems to carry a role beyond cooking. In many homes, a drawer full of dried red chillies and bay leaves isn't just about recipes, but it's part of seasonal rituals like stocking up before monsoon or sun-drying masalas in March before summer hits full swing.

What stands out to me is how naturally spices have become part of our everyday routines. No one pauses to measure out jeera or mustard seeds — you just add what feels right. Some steps, like tossing in curry leaves after the oil heats up, happen almost without thinking. Even in kitchens filled with gadgets and ready-to-eat packs, the basic spice process hasn't changed much. It's just something we all pick up, whether by watching our parents cook or figuring it out ourselves.

Spices and small wonders

One of my favourite things about spices is how they sneak in a little science. Take turmeric, did you know it can change colour when it meets something alkaline like soap or baking soda? It turns from yellow to red! Or how chilli tricks your brain into thinking your mouth is on fire, even though there's no heat at all?

Even something as common as mustard seeds behaves like a science experiment. Quiet one second, then suddenly popping and dancing in the oil the next. Cooking Indian food is full of these little reactions that make you feel like you're conducting experiments (except the results are edible).

A global love affair that started here

It's also worth remembering that Indian spices didn't just stay in India. People from across the world once travelled here for our spices. Black pepper was called "black gold" and traded like currency. Saffron, cardamom, and cinnamon were our exports before software and steel. And while those explorers may have come for the spices, they left with stories, techniques, and even parts of our culture.

In every spoon, there is a story

Living in India, it's easy to think of spices as routine. We smell them every day, and we use them without thinking. But the more I learn about them, the more I realise: they're not just "kitchen stuff." They're history, culture, memory, and yes, a bit of everyday science too.

So the next time you stir a curry or sip masala chai, pause for a second. That cinnamon stick or clove isn't just adding taste — it's carrying a piece of who we are, and where we come from.

Anushka Bahorey
Grade 11,
Singapore International School
(Mumbai)



Reels, recipes and the rise of AI: a tale of then and now



Girija Menon

There was a time, not too long ago (well, maybe 50 decades or so — who's counting?), when watching a movie on TV once a week was a grand event. For those of us who grew up in the 60s and 70s, that Sunday evening movie on Doordarshan was the highlight of our week. Neighbours would troop in, friends would plonk themselves on the floor (which was the VIP lounge back then), and we'd all squint at the screen as though it were a window to another galaxy. It was community bonding at its best—minus popcorn but with plenty of murukku, maybe lemon juice and murmurs.

Cut to this day recent times, and you've got movies, reels, shows, and gyan pouring out of every screen we own. Entertainment now fits into your palm and follows you into the loo. With a few hundred channels and streaming apps, we can't even remember what we watched yesterday. Attention span? Gone with the wind.

Reels today are the modern treadmill—for our thumbs. Scroll, scroll, scroll. You burn calories? No way, but lose brain cells in a big way. There's a reel for everything: from cutting a watermelon in 0.4 seconds to removing stains with toothpaste and heartbreak with Himalayan salt lamps. Life hacks, they call them. I tried one for a 2-minute mug cake. It came out as a 20-minute smoke bomb. Straight to the bin. Or sometimes, down the sink with what little hopes I had on my baking skills. Insta hope I call it, lifts you so much that you feel like a pro until a flop show and you are left scrubbing the pan for a few days in row.

We're now drowning in a sea of information—and its evil twin, misinformation. One day methi is a superfood, the next day it's causing hair fall. The vulnerable me believes everything. Yes, I'm that person who once started soaking raisins in gin because Instagram said it cures joint pain and bad vibes. Let's just say... it cleared nothing except the bottle real quick.

Add to this the reel-ification of real life. Every tragedy is turned into a story with dramatic music. Crimes become crime thrillers. Losses are documented like they're prepping for an Oscar. By the time we grasp the plot, the next breaking news has already "blasted" onto our screens. What happened to the last story? Who knows. Memory's short, attention spans are shorter, and empathy is now edited for runtime, likes, and statistics.

And now, we have AI. Our all-knowing, all-typing companion. I sometimes wonder—when we were so organically intelligent, why do we now need artificial intelligence? But here we are. Either we embrace it, or we risk becoming extinct like dial-up internet, landlines, and neighbourhood chitchats. With age I have realised, better to go with the flow and keep up or else be sidelined to become a recluse in some corner where no one wants to interact with you.

So, here's to those simpler times—when entertainment was rare, shared, and precious. And here's to now—when everything is on-demand, including confusion. Glad to have grown up in those times and also glad to be here (much older) in these times. Positive being – able to see two ends of the spectrum.

I'm still figuring it out by way of trial and error. And if you are too, welcome to the club. No reels, no algorithms—just real people trying to stay somewhat sane in this digital circus. If you are born to be part of the circus, might as well put up your best act on this stage.





(Girija Menon, the author, enjoys her passion for writing. Her first love is poetry; an astute observer of the world around us, she loves writing down her thoughts in both poems and prose. LIFE THREADS is what she uses to weave this one-of-a-kind fabric that spans reams. She can be reached at – whisperingverses@gmail.com)

Pṛthvī to Ākāśa: The Fivefold Foundation of all Creation (Part 1)

Earthing _ Syncing the Pṛthvī Tattva



Palak Sardana

Material world is a composite of five elements; ether, air, fire, water & earth. From time immemorial, these elements have been revered by various indigenous cultures around the world. In the Vedic period, nature's elements were ceremonially invoked, worshipped and partnered with to carry out various life processes. Awareness that all life depended on them made them sacrosanct in day to day living. The Nitya karma (daily obligatory duties) of 'Deva yajña' was performed everyday with the intention of expressing gratitude to the natural life sustaining forces like sun, fire, rain, wind etc. Rituals entailed homas, lamp lighting, mantra chanting or silent prayers to honour the elements and maintain Ṛta, the cosmic order.

The esoteric nature of five elements found a more practical expression in Ayurveda in the form of its core principle of tri-dosha (three doshas). These five elements combined in three different pairings produce specific gunas (properties/qualities) and direct Ayurveda's entire approach to health and healing.The first dosha Vāta is a combination of elements ether & air, Pitta, a combination of fire & water and Kapha, a combination of water & earth. While every being is a composite of all five elements, it is the unique proportion and play of these five that makes every individual different. However, the commonality of elements enabled the broad segregation into three doshas.

This verse from Caraka Samhita signifies the role of the five elements/tridoshas in the maintenance of our health and well-being; "Vāyuḥ pittam kaphaś ceti trayo doṣāḥ samāsataḥ | Vikṛtā deham ghnanti te vartayanti ca ||""Vāta, Pitta, and Kapha are the three Doṣhas. When imbalanced, they destroy the body; when in balance, they sustain it."The effort of all ayurvedic practices is to keep tri-doshas in balance. When they go out of balance, therapy (panch-karmas) and medicinal part of Ayurveda steps in to harmonise them.

The grossest of all elements' is earth. It is what gives structure and stability to our body & is responsible for our emotional security. 12-16% of our body mass is attributed to element earth. When in balance, the element has a positive physical and psychological impact and makes us feel rooted, safe and secure. Earth element also governs the base chakra, the muladhara, which is the foundation of our material existence. The stressful modern day living, hyper stimulation all around and extreme diets to lose weight or excessive eating due to food addictions or psychological issues can all disturb the delicate balance of this element. When in excess, it leads to weight gain, lethargy and dullness of the mind & body and when deficient, it leads to hyper-activity (ADHD kind of symptoms), spaciness, fear, restlessness, excessive attachment, brittle bones, muscle wasting & weight loss. In Ayurvedic terminology we can say that imbalance of earth element can lead to vata and kapha dosha disorders depending upon whether its in excess or deficit.

An extremely therapeutic yet simple and cost-effective practice to balance this element in the body is earthing/ grounding. Ayurveda recommends walking barefoot on grass or soil to balance the earth element effectively. When it is in excess (kapha tendency), the wet soil should be avoided. Bare earth, sand or dry mud are more suitable.

Today we are aware that earth carries a negative electrical charge which counters the negative impact of the high level of positive charge we all carry in the form of free radicals. When we walk barefoot on earth, negatively charged electrons move into our body and neutralise the positively charged free radicals thus reducing the oxidative stress and inflammation, the root cause behind most diseases. Skin contact with earth also activates the parasympathetic nervous system inducing calmness and stability. Earthing also normalises cortisol (stress hormone) secretion and improves



melatonin levels (the sleep hormone). It also improves heart rate variability (HRV), an indicator of a robust autonomic balance and emotional stability.

Beaches give access to both wet and dry sands as well as salts in sea water which can benefit all the three doshas. They also have high electron density due to constant wave action and effectively neutralise the free radicals producing anti-inflammatory &, immune-boosting effects in the body. Sand also provides natural acupressure and lymphatic stimulation while the sea air which is rich in negative ions, enhances mood and serotonin balance.

We all carry a part of mother earth within us. The least we can do for our physical & emotional well-being is attune to her energies. She is benevolent; a nourisher while we are alive and also our final resting place at the end of our lives. Let's re-establish our unbreakable bond with her by kicking off our shoes whenever an opportunity arises.

Prthvi devi namas tubhyam!

(Palak Sardana is a Harvard certified wellness coach, a mental health counsellor, yoga teacher & founder of wellness venture, Tranquility Unlimited. Via these articles, her endeavour is to present non-invasive & practical models of wellness grounded in ancient wisdom and modern scientific research. She runs ongoing wellness classes. For joining or booking a personalized consultation/session, write to tranquilityunlimited@gmail.com)

Say goodbye to fatty liver



Nisha Singh

Hepatic Steatosis or Non - Alcoholic Fatty Liver Disease (NAFLD) which is more commonly known as simply, Fatty liver is highly prevalent in the Indian population today. Studies show that anywhere between 9% to 32% of the Indian population could be afflicted with the disease. While there are several stages of NAFLD, most people fall somewhere in the middle of the stage spectrum for this disease.

Genetics, obesity, insulin resistance, high levels of cholesterol and triglycerides, polycystic ovarian syndrome, uncontrolled diabetes, thyroid issues, inflammation, chronic stress, poor sleep, consumption of excess food, consumption of processed foods, sedentary lifestyle, and even nutrient deficiencies are all causes for the development of this disease. Liver is where digestive juices are produced. Especially for fat metabolism. If the liver becomes slow and sluggish, good digestion of food does not happen. As a result, bloating, hyperacidity, higher levels of inflammation within the body, and toxin build up etc. tend to occur.

The good news though is that the liver as an organ is very resilient. Any step that you take to correct and reset your lifestyle and food habits go a long way in reversing liver damage.

- **Coffee**: Happy news for all the coffee lovers. Drinking up to two to three cups of black coffee daily offers liver protecting benefits. While research hasn't yet fully understood how coffee consumption helps protect the liver, it is believed that it increases the production of liver enzymes that help fight inflammation in the body. Antioxidants like chlorogenic acid help in preventing the build up of fat in the liver. Coffee consumption is also known to reduce scarring of the liver. Remember, if you are one of those that gets anxious or jittery upon drinking even small quantities of coffee, avoid it.

- **Turmeric**: One of the most potent anti-inflammatory foods, turmeric is well known for its healing and detoxifying properties. Research shows that not only does including turmeric in the diet bring down the inflammation within the body but it also helps to reduce elevated liver enzymes. A word of caution, there is a difference between turmeric consumed in food versus concentrated turmeric/curcumin bio-enhanced supplements. When high doses of concentrated curcumin are taken it can cause liver injury.

- **Balanced diet**: Fatty liver is a disease which is a result of both over-consumption as well as choosing the wrong foods. It is therefore extremely important to ensure that the food plate is balanced and includes all food groups as per an individual's required portion size. Include a good quality protein like meat, eggs, legumes, lentils, paneer, or other dairy products. Adequate quantity of greens like spinach, fenugreek, kale, amaranth leaves, moringa, lettuce etc. either as salads or vegetables and enough fiber in the diet. Inclusion of a variety of millets is recommended. Also, include a variety of fruits like apples, berries, Indian gooseberry etc, as well as omega -3 fatty rich foods like nuts and seeds. Avoid excess consumption of refined carbohydrates and ultra-processed food items. They add no value to the food plate but ensure that there is an insulin spike in the system which is detrimental to long term health. Over consumption of calories also leads to more fat storage causing the liver to either overwork. Over a period of time this leads to the liver becoming sluggish
.

- **Exercise**: Sedentary lifestyle is one of the risk factors for developing fatty liver disease. Include regular aerobic exercise like walking, swimming or cycling. Functional training as well as lifting weights both further help in not only improving muscle strength but also movement patterns. Exercising regularly will also ensure that an individual's weight is well managed. Being in the right body fat percent bracket will also help in reducing the stress on the liver.

- **Stress**: One of the keys to reduce inflammation in the body is to manage stress well. Long term elevated stress hormones like cortisol load the liver and increase fat storage. Also, today everyone is constantly hustling.In such scenarios it becomes all the more important that stress management techniques are a priority in everyone's daily routine. Practice pranayama and meditation regularly. Indulging in a hobby helps in lowering stress and helping one relax. Sit by the beach, read, hug a tree or journal. Do whatever speaks to you.

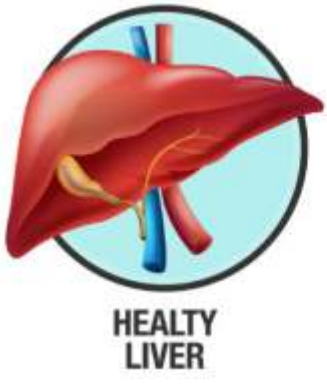
- **Sleep:** Another important pillar is sleep. Getting at least 7 to 8 hours of sleep every night supports the body's healing and repair response. It also helps in getting rid of all the toxins from the body thereby lowering inflammation.

Fatty liver disease is reversible if caught at the right time. Incorporate healthy changes in your life one step at a time to ensure a healthy liver and healthy digestion.

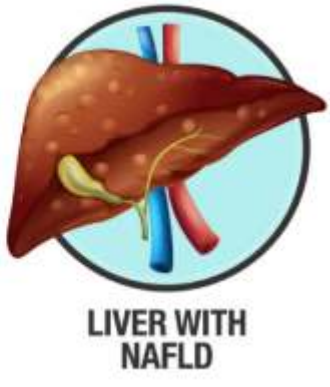
You can follow Dietitian Nisha on Instagram for nutrition & fitness tips and live interactive sessions at – nurtiwellness.by.dt.nishas

We at My Powai are taking our readers' queries related to Diet & Nutrition, which Ms. Nisha Singh will reply to in our forthcoming issues.

You can send your questions at: dietnutrition.queries@gmail.com



HEALTY LIVER



LIVER WITH NAFLD

(The writer is a gold medalist in Food & Nutrition with more than 12 years experience. She manages various ailments through lifestyle and dietary modifications and specializes in weight loss & management. She practices at 102, Crystal Center, Raheja Vihar, Powai or Smile Craft, 23, Annapurna Industrial estate, Opp. CCD, Ghatkopar East. For appointments: 022 2857 6537 Email: singhnisha@gmail.com)

Exploring the unchartered flavours of Northeast India



Sherry Bhatnagar

Welcome to a culinary journey through Northeast India, an often-overlooked treasure trove of bold, earthy flavours and deeply rooted traditions. This vibrant region—home to the "Seven Sisters"— has nurtured a food culture largely untouched by mainland culinary conventions. Its dishes preserve tribal heritage, local wisdom, and foraged bounty. Flavour doesn't come from heavy oils or masalas, but from fresh indigenous ingredients.

Step into the culinary heart of Northeast India—where fermented staples like Ngari and bamboo vessel cooking meet the fierce whisper of Bhut Jolokia, the legendary ghost pepper. This food isn't merely cooked, it's crafted: smoke, umami, and heritage fused in every bite, creating a vibrant tapestry of flavours that thrive on simplicity, ritual, and the wild bounty of hill and forest."

To start with ...kuchh meetha ho jaye.... though I fondly love Tilor Laru & Narikol Ladu, but I am sharing - Madhurjan Thongba- the heavenly dish of Manipur.



Madhurjan Thongba (Sweet Besan Dumplings in Milk)
Serves - 2/3

Ingredients
½ cup besan (gram flour)
Pinch of salt
A pinch baking soda
1 tsp ghee or butter
1 tsp sugar (for the dough)
Oil for deep frying
2 cups full fat milk
2 tsp + 2 tbsp sugar (divided)
1 bay leaf
½ tsp cardamom powder
2 tbsp grated fresh coconut (optional)
1–2 tbsp chopped nuts (cashews, almonds, pistachios) – optional

Method of Preparation
Prepare the dough
- In a bowl, mix besan, salt, baking soda, 1 tsp sugar, and ghee. Add enough water to form a stiff, chapati-like dough.

Shape & fry dumplings
- Heat oil in a small pan. Pinch small marble-sized balls from the dough. Fry in batches over medium heat until golden brown. Drain on paper towels

Flavour the milk
- In a saucepan, bring milk to a simmer. Add 2 tbsp sugar, bay leaf, and nuts if using. Cook for 5–8 minutes until the milk reduces slightly and flavours infuse.
- Combine dumplings and milk
- Lower the heat, gently add the fried dumplings, and simmer for another 2–4 minutes to let them absorb the milk.

Finish & serve
- Turn off the heat then stir in coconut and cardamom powder. Serve hot or chilled.

Pro Tips
- For a richer texture, substitute 1 cup of milk with evaporated milk
- Dumpling size: marble size gives a pleasant chew; larger balls create a more substantial bite.
- Let it rest for 10 minutes before serving cold—they absorb creamy flavour even better.



Kelli Chana (Manipur-Style Spicy Chickpeas)
Serves: 3–4

Ingredients
1 cup white peas (soaked overnight) or chickpeas
1 tbsp. oil + handful mustard oil (optional for traditional flavor)
1 bay leaf
½ tsp turmeric powder, salt
½ tsp ginger paste, 1 tsp garlic paste
1–2 green chilies, slit/chopped
1 onion, sliced
½ tsp coriander powder, 1 tsp roasted cumin powder
½ tsp red chili flakes or powder
3 tbsp garlic chives or spring onion greens
1 tsp kitchen-king masala (optional)
1 tbsp chopped fresh coriander
1 tbsp lemon juice (optional twist)

Method of Preparation
Cook the peas/chickpeas
Drain soaked peas; boil with turmeric & salt until tender (or pressure cook, 3 whistles). Drain.
Sauté aromatics
Heat oil (mix in mustard oil for extra zing), add the bay leaf, ginger, garlic, chilies, and onions. Cook until onions turn golden.
Spice it up
Stir in coriander, cumin, chili flakes, and kitchen king masala if using. Sauté briefly.
Combine & finish
Add the boiled peas, toss to coat with spices, and cook for 2–3 minutes. Stir in garlic chives or spring onions, chopped coriander, and lemon juice. Remove bay leaf and serve hot.



Khorisa Bhaji (Assamese Bamboo Shoot Fry)
Serves 4

Ingredients
500 g fresh bamboo shoots, boiled & diced
2 tbsp mustard oil (for traditional flavour)
1 medium onion, finely chopped
2 green chilies, chopped
1 tsp turmeric powder
Salt to taste

Method of Preparation
Heat oil in a pan over medium flame. Add onions and chilies; sauté until onions turn translucent.
Stir in bamboo shoots, turmeric, and salt.
Cook for 5–7 minutes until the shoots absorb the spice and soften slightly.
Serve hot, ideally with steamed rice or alongside kebabs, fish curries, or dal.

(Sherry Bhatnagar is the founder of Anubhuti Food Ventures — a passionate food visionary, avid traveller and wellness advocate. With a deep-rooted belief that food is one of the purest expressions of care, she champions traditional Indian flavours, forgotten recipes, and nourishing meals. Through her writing, she invites readers to rediscover the emotional and cultural richness of home-cooked food, and the timeless wisdom that simmers in every regional dish.)

August 2025



Richa Pathak

Aries (Mar 21 - Apr 19)
Your decisions in August carry long-term weight. This is not the month to multitask or chase quick wins—pick one path and follow it with quiet determination. A mentor figure could guide you professionally. Avoid letting pride disrupt conversations with loved ones. Lucky Color: Brick Red. Lucky Day: Tuesday. Remedy: Light a mustard oil lamp at Hanuman temple and chant "Hanuman Ashtak" to release suppressed anger and gain clarity in leadership.

Taurus (Apr 20 - May 20)
Stillness becomes your power this month. Rather than pushing forward, step back and observe what you've built. Your financial instincts are sharp—trust your first impression. Emotionally, nostalgia may resurface—reach out, but only if peace follows. Lucky Color: Forest Green. Lucky Day: Saturday. Remedy: Place a Shree Yantra on raw earth (mitti) and offer a camphor flame every Saturday to amplify inner calm and secure income streams.

Gemini (May 21 - Jun 20)
The spotlight is on your voice—literally or figuratively. Whether through speaking, writing, or leading a discussion, you're called to influence. However, unspoken fears may surface in your relationships. Face them before they fester. Lucky Color: Mustard Yellow. Lucky Day: Wednesday. Remedy: Meditate while facing east and feed jaggery-coated roasted gram to birds to sharpen intellect and release blocked expression.

Cancer (Jun 21 - Jul 22)
Security—emotional, financial, or spiritual—becomes a top theme. Don't ignore gut feelings about people or places. A surprising offer at work could arrive, but clarity must override excitement. On the personal front, silence will say more than explanations. Lucky Color: Ivory. Lucky Day: Monday. Remedy: Offer raw milk to a Shivling before sunrise and place a white flower at your doorstep to absorb emotional restlessness.

Leo (Jul 23 - Aug 22)
Your season may boost confidence, but the real test lies in how you channel your fire. Recognition is close, but only if you resist the urge to control outcomes. In love, a shift in expectations may either heal or end something permanently. Lucky Color: Copper. Lucky Day: Sunday. Remedy: Offer red hibiscus to the Sun and chant "Aditya Hridayam" for purification of ego and enhanced decision-making.

Virgo (Aug 23 - Sep 22)
The structure you love may temporarily dissolve this month—but don't panic. Something better is being rebuilt behind the scenes. Embrace spiritual discomfort; it will pass. Focus on restoring your sleep, boundaries, and breathing rhythms. Lucky Color: Dusty Blue. Lucky Day: Thursday. Remedy: Light a sandalwood incense stick daily and offer a single Tulsi leaf to Lord Vishnu for karmic closure and restored inner order.



Libra (Sep 23 - Oct 22)
You'll find yourself reevaluating alliances. Some friendships may fade quietly, while others deepen with purpose. Professionally, team dynamics will test your diplomacy. Avoid chasing balance—create it. Lucky Color: Smoky Pink. Lucky Day: Friday. Remedy: Place a rose quartz pyramid in your bedroom's southwest corner and chant "Om Draam Dreem Draum Sah Shukraya Namah" on Friday evenings.

Scorpio (Oct 23 - Nov 21)
You're being called to lead—but this time, from behind the curtain. Influence without control, and power will follow. A professional shift may feel unsettling but carries hidden rewards. In relationships, protect your energy from emotional vampires. Lucky Color: Indigo. Lucky Day: Tuesday. Remedy: On Tuesdays, offer a pinch of red sindoor and five cloves to Mars in your altar. Chant "Om Bhaumaya Namah" for focused transformation.

Sagittarius (Nov 22 - Dec 21)
You crave movement—physically or mentally. If you've been contemplating a shift in your environment, August offers divine timing. Travel, study, or spiritual guidance will reshape your thinking. Let curiosity guide, but avoid impulsive exits. Lucky Color: Royal Purple. Lucky Day: Thursday. Remedy: Offer a yellow marigold to Lord Brihaspati and recite "Om Guruve Namah" for expansion through wisdom, not rebellion.

Capricorn (Dec 22 - Jan 19)
This month brings karmic balancing—what you've given, you may now receive. Financial blocks may lift, but only through ethical decisions. A past connection could resurface—choose wisdom over emotion. Lucky Color: Slate Grey. Lucky Day: Saturday. Remedy: Offer sesame oil to a Peepal tree and chant "Om Nilanjana Samabhasam" for dissolving burdens and clearing unseen delays.

Aquarius (Jan 20 - Feb 18)
Contracts, commitments, and promises need extra attention. Before signing or saying "yes," pause. A personal relationship may reach a turning point—what you compromise on today, you'll live with tomorrow. Lucky Color: Teal. Lucky Day: Monday. Remedy: Wear a silver chain around your ankle and chant "Om Som Somaya Namah" on Mondays to anchor emotions and sharpen discernment.

Pisces (Feb 19 - Mar 20)
Details demand your attention now. Whether it's your health, routine, or missed obligations—neglect will catch up. But here's the gift: small efforts will bring profound shifts. Creative energy flows if it's grounded. Lucky Color: Ocean Green Lucky Day: Sunday Remedy: Offer water infused with tulsi to a banana plant and chant "Om Namo Bhagavate Vasudevaya" for grounding spiritual energy into action.

(Astrologer Richa Pathak masters the art of Astrology, Vastu & Numerology. In-person consultation with prior appointment can be done at 207, Lantana, Nahar Amrit Shakti, Chandivali, Powai. She also gives Virtual Consultation & can be reached @ 8 4 5 2 9 2 0 6 4 0 & www.jyotishdham.com)